

DANESH JASSAWALA

Netflix's Scoop, based on a book by journalist Jigna Vora, traces a reporter's struggle as she is arrested in connection with a murder

ENTERTAINMENT

DIRECTOR IN DEMAND

HANSAL MEHTA'S PENCHANT FOR LONG-FORM STORYTELLING AND GETTING UNDER THE SKIN OF AN ISSUE COME TOGETHER IN HIS LATEST OTT SERIES, *SCOOP*

Director Hansal Mehta's career has had two pivotal moments: *Shahid* (2012) and *Scam 1992: The Harshad Mehta Story* (2020). After directing the National Award-winning biopic about a human rights lawyer, Mehta gained credence as a filmmaker with a pertinent socio-political perspective; post the SonyLIV series about the infamous stockbroker, he became one of the most sought-after directors for OTT shows. "I see myself as a chronicler of the times we live in," says Mehta, "through the stories of people who are either forgotten or are on the fringes but have actually made a significant contribution to our social consciousness."

That quest continues with **Netflix's** *Scoop*, his second series (he was creative producer on AltBalaji's *Bose: Dead/Alive*, 2017), in which he focuses on crime reporter Jagruti (Karishma Tanna), whose life turns upside down when she is arrested in connection with the murder of a fellow journalist. Inspired by the book *Behind Bars in Byculla: My Days in Prison* by journalist Jigna Vora, *Scoop* is about a reporter's "life and aspirations" and her struggle to clear her name, as well as a deep dive into the functioning of the fourth estate in a precarious environment. Says Mehta, "A journalist's life has never been under greater threat and journalism has never been a greater threat than it is today."

With *Scoop*, Mehta's penchant for dramas continues. "In films, the moment you categorise something as a drama, they say it doesn't work," says Mehta. "[On OTT] people gravitate towards drama." Mehta roped in writer Mrunmayee Lagoo Waikul (*Thappad*, 2020), who is also the showrunner, to explore aspects such as the investigation of a crime, how a daily newsroom works and an ambitious woman hustling in what's seen as a man's turf.

Mehta has taken to long-format storytelling like a fish to the ocean. "I have discovered a style of communication with the audience in that I take the character into the homes of people," he says, citing how there was empathy for Harshad Mehta despite his wrongdoings. *Scam's* success has resulted in the director being busier than ever before. Apart from *Scoop*, Mehta's 2023 releases include *Scam 2003: The Telgi Story*, on which he is a showrunner. There's also a film with Kareena Kapoor Khan, and *Lootere*, a Disney+ Hotstar series that he helms, directed by his son Jai Mehta.

Seated at the Netflix office in Mumbai, Mehta points to his small backpack, which carries a script he plans on reading during breaks while promoting *Scoop*. "I am not doing anything I don't want to," he says. "If you do that, then you get into a trap. I have done films in the past that consumed me so much emotionally that I could not do any other work." The pandemic brought a much-needed change in perspective. Adds Mehta, "How much do you need? What do you want? It is better to walk out than do something you don't want to." ■

Suhani Singh